

1. The History — Decades of Theoretical Priority Have Not Solved the Education–Employment Gap

1.1. The gap in the education sector

Reasoning

Since independence in 1971, Bangladesh has expanded formal education around academic progression, examinations and qualifications. The result is a system where educational success is strongly associated with completing the next academic level and obtaining certificates and degrees.

The problem is not that theoretical knowledge is useless.

The problem is that this emphasis has not been matched by sufficient development of the **life skills** that allow a person to deal effectively with real-world demands: communication, problem-solving, decision-making, adaptability, teamwork, responsibility and other psychosocial abilities needed in everyday life and work.

This gap has been recognised for decades. A World Bank review of Bangladesh's education system found that secondary education and examinations placed strong emphasis on rote memorisation, while many students were left inadequately prepared for the realities of life and work. ([World Bank](#))

So our historical argument is not that Bangladesh has had “too much education.”

It is that Bangladesh has given **greater institutional importance to what students can reproduce academically than to how effectively they can function outside the classroom.**

Example

The World Bank found that Bangladeshi employers considered skills such as **critical thinking, problem-solving, communication, teamwork, leadership and adaptability** essential, but identified major weaknesses among Bangladeshi youth in precisely these areas. ([World Bank](#))

This means that after years of formal education, students can still leave the system without the life skills required to deal effectively with workplace demands.

Linking

The evidence establishes the historical imbalance.

Bangladesh has built an extensive formal education system, but employers continue to identify major gaps in the practical and psychosocial abilities that allow graduates to function effectively in real life and work.

Therefore, the problem is not simply a lack of education.

It is a lack of **balance** between theoretical attainment and life skills.

And that is exactly why the motion asks institutions to change their emphasis.

1.2. How it affects the job sector, creating unemployment and an unskilled workforce

Reasoning

When institutions produce academically qualified people without sufficiently developing life skills, education does not automatically translate into employability.

A graduate may understand a subject theoretically but struggle to communicate professionally, solve unfamiliar problems, work in teams, adapt to workplace expectations or make decisions independently.

This produces a dangerous paradox: people can be **educated but not adequately prepared for employment**.

The World Bank found that tertiary-educated unemployment in Bangladesh was significantly higher than overall unemployment, while graduate-tracer evidence showed substantial unemployment even among people who had completed higher education. ([World Bank Blogs](#))

Example

In July 2026, ILO Bangladesh documented the case of a young man in Chattogram who had completed a four-year diploma in mechanical technology. Three months later, he was still unemployed. He explained that he had learned what was in the syllabus but did not know whether it matched what factories actually needed.

The ILO identified this education-to-employment gap as one of Bangladesh's biggest obstacles and specifically highlighted employers' demand for **communication, problem-solving, teamwork, digital literacy and the ability to learn on the job**. ([International Labour Organization](#))

Linking

This is the clearest demonstration of our argument.

The graduate had a formal qualification, but qualification alone had not enabled him to deal effectively with the demands of the labour market.

Therefore, the historical emphasis on academic attainment has not been sufficient to solve unemployment and skills mismatch.

The solution is not to remove theoretical education.

The solution is to give greater emphasis to the life skills that allow graduates to actually **use their knowledge, adapt to work and respond to real-world challenges**.

2. The Present — Life Skills Create Economic Mobility

2.1. Life skills create economic mobility

Reasoning

Economic mobility occurs when people can improve their income, employment and financial stability.

Life skills directly contribute to this because they determine how effectively individuals respond to real economic situations.

Communication helps people interact with employers, customers and colleagues.

Problem-solving helps them handle situations that are not already explained in a textbook.

Decision-making helps them choose between opportunities and risks.

Adaptability allows them to respond when jobs, technologies or circumstances change.

Financial self-management helps them handle income and everyday economic responsibilities.

These are all abilities that fit our definition of life skills because they enable people to deal effectively with the demands and challenges of everyday life and work.

Example

BRAC's STAR programme in Bangladesh combines occupational training with **life skills and practical workplace exposure**. Its evaluation found increased labour-market participation and earnings, with increased earnings also improving household welfare through greater food expenditure and durable-asset ownership. ([BRAC Bangladesh](#))

More recent BRAC reporting says its skills model has produced a **22.6% rise in labour-market participation, 78% more income-generating activities**, and an average **78% increase in household income** after skills training. ([BRAC Bangladesh](#))

Linking

The important point is that life skills created an economic outcome.

The participants were not simply more knowledgeable.

They became better able to deal with workplace and livelihood demands, and that translated into employment, income and improved household welfare.

Therefore, life skills are not merely “nice qualities.”

They are part of the mechanism through which education becomes **economic mobility**.

This directly supports the motion: institutions should place greater emphasis on the abilities that allow students to function effectively in the real economy.

2.2. How we make it possible — the 20+ hours-per-month system

Reasoning

The Opposition may argue that life skills are too broad to be taught systematically.

Our response is that life skills can be deliberately practised and assessed.

We propose allocating **20+ hours every month**, approximately five hours per week, specifically to life-skills development.

These hours should focus on practical situations rather than memorising definitions.

Students can practise communication, teamwork, decision-making, financial management, problem-solving, adaptability, negotiation, entrepreneurship and workplace behaviour through projects, simulations, supervised activities and real-world exposure.

The purpose is not to replace theoretical classes.

It is to ensure that students repeatedly practise the abilities needed to deal effectively with the demands and challenges they will face outside the institution.

Example

Bangladesh is already testing this principle.

In 2026, the ILO reported that a re-modelled industrial-attachment programme was helping diploma graduates become more workplace-ready by bringing **industries and polytechnic institutions** closer together. The programme was created specifically to address the persistent gap between education and employment. ([International Labour Organization](#))

Linking

This proves that institutional exposure to real-world demands is possible.

The 20+ hours model simply makes that principle systematic rather than occasional.

Instead of hoping students develop communication, decision-making, teamwork and problem-solving naturally, institutions deliberately create situations where students must practise them.

Therefore, greater emphasis on life skills is not an unrealistic demand.

It is an achievable institutional reform that directly targets Bangladesh's existing education-employment mismatch.

3. The Future — Life Skills Today Create the Conditions for Theoretical Excellence Tomorrow

3.1. Current generation: life skills create economically mobile workers

Reasoning

The effect of life skills does not stop with the individual graduate.

When people become better able to deal with workplace and economic challenges, they are more capable of securing employment, maintaining income, making informed decisions and managing household resources.

This produces **economic mobility**.

Economic mobility then produces something even more important: **household stability**.

Example

BRAC's evidence shows that skills training increased earnings and that those higher earnings translated into greater household welfare, including increased food expenditure and ownership of durable assets. ([BRAC Bangladesh](#))

Linking

The individual therefore becomes more than employable.

The individual becomes economically capable.

And once economic capability reaches the household, the impact extends beyond the current generation.

3.2. Household stability creates greater educational opportunity for children

Reasoning

A financially unstable household has to prioritise immediate survival.

A more economically stable household has greater ability to invest in children's education, maintain schooling and absorb unexpected financial pressures.

Therefore:

Life skills → better functioning in work and life → economic mobility → household stability → greater educational opportunity for children.

This is why giving greater emphasis to life skills today can create better conditions for theoretical education tomorrow.

Example

BRAC's skills evidence shows that higher earnings from skills interventions improved household welfare, while its broader skills programmes connect employability and income improvement with longer-term household development. ([BRAC Bangladesh](#))

Linking

The point is not that life skills directly teach children advanced mathematics or science.

The point is that life skills help create the **economic conditions** in which children have a greater opportunity to pursue those subjects.

That makes life skills a foundation for, rather than an enemy of, theoretical education.

3.3. Future generation: greater stability allows deeper theoretical learning and innovation

Reasoning

Our model is therefore intergenerational:

Life skills → economic mobility → household stability → educational opportunity → advanced theoretical skills → innovation.

The current generation needs institutions to produce people who can effectively deal with the demands of work and everyday economic life.

The next generation can then build on that stability by spending more time developing advanced theoretical knowledge.

This is how the two forms of skill complement each other across generations.

Linking

Therefore, the Government is not saying Bangladesh should abandon theoretical education.

We are saying that **today's institutions should give greater emphasis to life skills because they solve today's immediate problem—whether people can effectively function in real life and work—while creating the stability from which tomorrow's deeper theoretical education can grow.**

That is why life skills deserve greater emphasis now.